

Figure 7. Assi Ghat

The state, however, wants to dismantle the ghatwars' hereditary rights. In 1997, the Nagar Nigam (municipal authority) began licensing boats of anyone who qualified.[40] Even non-Mallahs were issued licenses to ply their own boats. But so far, the powerful ghatwars from the lucrative ghats have managed to defend and enforce the traditional rules of the game. They've prevented all rebellious Mallahs and outsiders from establishing themselves, even using violence at times.[41]

At the same time, certain moral obligations and reciprocity within the community also support a kind of safety net for all boatmen, writes Doron, whereby privileged Mallahs find small jobs for other Mallahs who seek work in the riverine economy. This would vanish if the state dismantled their caste-bound, hereditary arrangements by force (an option the state hasn't pursued yet). So while the system has much unfairness, the statist alternative may seem worse to most Mallahs.